

How to shoot

5.1 Macro

A macro is a close-up shot of a really small subject, typically with a small depth of field. There are two important considerations to make with the regular point and shoot cameras. The first, and obvious step is to put the camera in the macro mode. This increases the aperture, and gives a very narrow plane of focus. The second step is to adjust the focus. Turn off the autofocus, when you click the photograph, as the autofocus is likely to get confused and take a long time adjusting when you take your lens really close to the subject. There is a very narrow plane of focus, which should ideally be towards the front of the subject.

While shooting outdoors, the two most common macro subjects are flowers and insects. Often, while photographing extremely small flowers, the camera can focus on the background foliage, or on blades of grass in the foreground. The leaves, thorns or other aspects of the flower may show up focussed, but the flower itself will be blurry. This difference will not be apparent in the small screen of the camera, and such mistakes tend to be discovered only after the photos have been transferred to a computer. Manual focussing is very important in macro photography. Do not hesitate to re-arrange the subject a bit to get a good shot. Ask someone to shield the flower from wind, if that gives you problems. Macro photography in the night is not a good idea, and the camera will cast a shadow on the flash for close-ups. It's a good idea to use reflectors to cast light on the subject. This does not need complicated equipment, tissue papers, paper or white sheets will do just great. If the flash is overexposing the flower, a good idea is to shield or mask the flash a bit using tissue paper, or covering half the flash with your fingers (this sometimes gives a red cast to the image). When it comes to photographing flowers, it is always preferable to take the lens closer rather than using the zoom.

Photographing insects is a bit tricky. This is because they don't stay still long enough to make elaborate adjustments.